Sœur Thérèse de l'Enfant-Jésus — Histoire d'une âme: Chapters I–VIII of the 1898 Pauline Composite

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 17 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the subject reviewers are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

This dossier presents Chapters I–VIII of XII only, translated from the 1912 Lisieux printing (Project Gutenberg No. 36708), which the edition holds to reproduce the 1898 composite unchanged — a collation against the 1898 first impression is outstanding.

Dedication

To Pauline Martin, in religion Mother Agnes of Jesus, who commanded these notebooks, received them, and after her sister's death gathered, joined, edited, and saw them into print. The 1898 book masked her part behind another name; this dossier restores her by name.

The author's own terms

“The science of love” is Thérèse's phrase near the close of Chapter VIII: the science she desires, drawn from “the Book of life,” for which she reckons she has given all her riches. The offering to Merciful Love is the chapter's governing act: on 9 June 1895 she offered herself, in the folder's rendering, not as a victim to God's justice but as a “holocaust victim to your Love.”

The story

Marie-Françoise-Thérèse Martin was born on 2 January 1873 at Alençon. Her mother died on 28 August 1877. She entered the Carmel of Lisieux on 9 April 1888, aged fifteen, joining her sisters Pauline and Marie; Céline followed later. She made her profession on 8 September 1890; her father died on 29 July 1894. Tuberculosis came in the night of 2–3 April 1896, and she died of it on 30 September 1897, aged twenty-four.

The notebooks were written at Pauline's command, for Pauline, who edited them into one book. The rendering here covers Chapters I–VIII only and is translated from the 1912 Lisieux printing (Project Gutenberg No. 36708), which the edition holds to reproduce the 1898 composite unchanged — a collation against the 1898 first impression is outstanding. Thérèse died an obscure cloistered nun; within about a year that composite became the shape in which the world first met her.

The work and what survives

Histoire d'une âme, écrite par elle-même was published at Bar-le-Duc by the Imprimerie Saint-Paul in October 1898, in 2,000 copies of 475 pages, financed by her uncle Isidore Guérin. The date is in dissent: long believed 30 September 1898, it is given by Conrad De Meester's critical edition as 20 October 1898 at Bar-le-Duc, received at Lisieux on 21 October. Pauline wove three manuscripts into one composite, her editorial notes flagged as hers in the folder. The folder's rendering is translated from the 1912 Lisieux printing (Project Gutenberg No. 36708), which the edition holds to reproduce the 1898 composite unchanged — a collation against the 1898 first impression is outstanding.

This project holds Chapters I–VIII only, in three files totalling 40,687 words, ending with the Act of Offering to Merciful Love of 9 June 1895, with which Chapter VIII closes Manuscript A in this printing. Chapters IX–XII are absent; the folder promises them as forthcoming.

Its English fortunes

English versions exist, and no general gap is claimed. A translation appeared in 1901; Thomas N. Taylor's 1912 edition was billed as a new and complete translation, in eleven chapters with an epilogue; John Clarke's 1975

translation, from the original manuscripts, is the modern standard. The bound: web searches run on 16 October 2026 for this dossier, with no WorldCat sweep and Project Gutenberg No. 36708 not independently opened.

Chapters I–VIII of the 1898 Pauline composite, Englished fresh from the French (1912 Lisieux printing, Project Gutenberg No. 36708) without consultation of the existing English versions, which date from 1901 onward.

What completing it would take

First, translate Chapters IX–XII, the stated remainder, from the same basis. Second, collate that basis: the rendering is translated from the 1912 Lisieux printing (Project Gutenberg No. 36708), which the edition holds to reproduce the 1898 composite unchanged — a collation against the 1898 first impression is outstanding, so a scan of the 1898 first impression must be checked against the 1912 printing, chapter by chapter, until the caveat can be dropped or the basis corrected. Third, settle the chapter division and the October date against the first impression. Fourth, obtain review by a reader of French; the folder carries none.

Sources

- Project folder: `~/workspace/rare-and-obscure-books/books/histoire-dune-ame-1898-english/` — files p1 (Chapters I–IV), p2 (Chapters V–VIII), p3 (Chapter VIII, closing note)
- PIN: `~/workspace/packages/boneyard-extension/research/PIN-histoire-1898.md`
- Taylor edition front matter and contents: https://cod.pressbooks.pub/womenlifewriting/chapter/the-project-gutenberg-ebook-of-the-story-of-a-soul-lhistoire-dune-ame-the-autobiography-of-st-therese-by-saint-de-lisieux-theres/
- Anniversary articles, thereseoflisieux.org; Thérèse reference record; John Paul II apostolic-letter material — as returned in the research run